Use AI before you need it.

I got laid off, spent five months getting back in, and learned what actually helps. This kit is what I wish I'd had on day one: what to do, in what order, and the exact words to get AI to do the heavy lifting.

HOW TO USE THIS KIT

1. Open ChatGPT, Claude or Gemini. The free versions work.
2. Find the moment you're in, copy the prompt, and replace anything in [brackets] with your details.
3. Paste your own documents where it says [paste]. Remove names, salary details you don't want shared, and anything confidential first.
4. Do the **Then** step under each prompt. The prompt gets you a draft; the Then step is what moves your situation forward.
5. Read everything before you send it. Never let AI invent numbers or facts about you.

WHAT'S INSIDE

- 30 prompts in 6 sections: the notice day, severance, resume, LinkedIn, interviews, and protecting the job you have
- A worked example showing a weak resume bullet turned into a strong one
- Your first 14 days after a layoff, day by day
- A "before you sign" severance checklist

6 of these prompts are also in my free prompt library; they're marked. This kit is general guidance, not legal, financial or medical advice. For your severance agreement, check with HR or an employment lawyer.

If it doesn't help, you get your $9 back. Email theaicareerfirewall@gmail.com within 30 days with the subject REFUND. No questions.

1. THE DAY YOU GET THE NOTICE

1 Sort out your first 48 hours

```
I was just told my job is being eliminated. My last day is [date]. Make a checklist of what to do in the next 48 hours, in order: what to ask HR before I leave, what personal files and contacts I'm allowed to keep, and who to tell first. Keep it to 10 items.
```

Then: Do the first 3 items today. Ask HR in writing what you're allowed to take before copying anything.

2 Questions to ask HR before you sign anything

```
My employer is laying me off. Write 12 clear questions to ask HR about final pay, unused vacation, health coverage end date, bonus, equity, and reference policy. Group them by topic.
```

Then: Send them in one email so the answers are in writing. Keep the reply with your agreement.

3 A calm goodbye to your team

```
Write a short, positive goodbye message to my team. I'm leaving because of a layoff. Thank them, share my personal email and LinkedIn, and keep it under 80 words. No bitterness.
```

Then: Send it before your access is cut. These people are your best referral source for the next year.

4 Your money runway in one table

```
Here are my monthly expenses and savings: [paste]. Build a table showing how many months I can last, which costs I can cut first, and the date I'd need a new paycheck by.
```

Then: Put that date on your calendar. Check your state's unemployment rules the same day; many states want you to file in your first week.

5 Turn panic into a 2-week plan

```
I was laid off today. Give me a realistic 2-week plan: one goal per day, nothing bigger than 2 hours, mixing job search, rest and money tasks.
```

Then: Compare it with the 14-day checklist at the back of this kit and keep whichever you'll actually follow.

2. SEVERANCE AND BENEFITS

6 Find everything you can negotiate

also in the free library

```
Here is my severance letter with names removed: [paste]. List every term I could ask to improve, what's reasonable to ask for, and draft a polite email asking for it. Note anything I should check with HR or an employment lawyer.
```

Then: Ask before you sign, not after. The worst answer is no, and you're no worse off.

7 Decode the agreement in plain English

```
Explain this separation agreement in plain English: [paste]. What am I giving up by signing, what are the deadlines, and what does each clause mean for me? List anything that's unusual or worth asking a lawyer about.
```

Then: If anything on the list worries you, a one-hour consult with an employment lawyer usually costs less than one week of pay.

8 Compare health coverage options

```
My employer coverage ends on [date]. Compare the general pros and cons of continuing my current plan (COBRA), joining a spouse's plan, and buying a marketplace plan. Give me the questions to ask each one.
```

Then: Losing job-based coverage usually opens a special enrollment window for marketplace plans. Check the deadline at healthcare.gov.

9 Ask for a written reference

```
Write a short, polite email to my manager asking for a written reference or LinkedIn recommendation before my last day. Mention 2 projects: [list].
```

Then: Offer to draft it for them. Managers say yes far more often when the work is done for them.

10 Track every deadline

```
From this agreement and these HR emails [paste], list every date and deadline I need to act on, in order, in a table.
```

Then: Copy each date into your phone calendar with a reminder two days early.

3. RESUME

11 Rewrite your weakest bullet with a number

also in the free library

```
Rewrite this as one resume bullet that shows an outcome with a number. If you need a number I didn't give you, ask me. Don't make one up: [bullet]
```

Then: Do this for your top 3 bullets in each recent job. See the worked example on the next page.

12 Match your resume to a job post

```
Here is my resume [paste] and a job posting [paste]. List the 10 most important keywords in the posting and show where my resume covers or misses each one.
```

Then: Only add keywords for things you've actually done. Use the posting's exact wording.

13 Cut it to one strong page

```
Shorten this resume to one page for a [target role]. Keep the last 10 years, the strongest results, and anything that matches the role. Tell me what you cut and why.
```

Then: Keep the long version too. You'll pull from it for different postings.

14 Explain the layoff in one line

```
Write one honest line for my resume or cover letter explaining that my role was eliminated in a layoff on [date]. Confident, not defensive.
```

Then: Layoffs are common and recruiters know it. One line is enough, then move on to what you did.

15 Show you use AI at work

```
Based on my job [describe], suggest 3 honest resume bullets showing how I use AI tools to save time or improve quality. Only use examples I confirm are true.
```

Then: Delete any bullet you couldn't explain in an interview.

4. LINKEDIN AND OUTREACH

16 A headline recruiters search for

```
Write 5 LinkedIn headline options for a [role] with [X] years in [industry], under 220 characters, using words recruiters search for.
```

Then: Pick one and use the same keywords in your About section and recent job titles.

17 An About section in your voice

```
Write a LinkedIn About section from my resume [paste]: 3 short paragraphs, first person, one result with a number, and what I'm looking for next.
```

Then: Read it out loud. If it doesn't sound like you, tell the AI which lines feel off and ask again.

18 Reconnect without sounding desperate

```
Write a short message to a former coworker I haven't talked to in 2 years. Catch up genuinely, mention I'm exploring [role], and ask one easy question.
```

Then: Send 3 a day. Most jobs after a layoff come from people who already know your work.

19 Ask for a referral the right way

```
Write a referral request to [name] at [company] for this posting [paste]. Make it easy to say yes: include 3 lines they can forward.
```

Then: Attach your resume and the job link so they don't have to look anything up.

20 Find 20 companies worth targeting

```
I'm a [role] in [location/remote] with skills in [list]. Suggest 20 types of companies or teams likely to hire someone like me, and why each fits.
```

Then: Turn the types into real company names on LinkedIn, then find one person at each you can message.

5. INTERVIEWS

21 Tell me about yourself in 45 seconds also in the free library

```
Write a 45-second answer to 'tell me about yourself': my current role, one result with a number, and why this job. Plain words. My resume: [paste]
```

Then: Time yourself saying it. Cut anything that pushes past 45 seconds.

22 Answer 'why did you leave?'

```
Write a short, honest answer to 'why did you leave your last job?' My role was cut in a layoff. Keep it positive and turn it toward what I want next.
```

Then: Practice it until it's boring. A calm, short answer is what interviewers want here.

23 Predict their questions

```
Here's the job posting [paste]. List the 10 questions I'm most likely to be asked, and for each, which story from my resume to use.
```

Then: Write the 5 stories you'll reuse most and turn each into a STAR answer with the next prompt.

24 Build STAR stories from your notes

```
Turn this messy story into a STAR answer (Situation, Task, Action, Result) under 90 seconds: [story]. Keep my real details; ask me for anything missing.
```

Then: End every story with a result and a number, even a rough one you can back up.

25 Questions that make you stand out

```
Write 6 sharp questions to ask at the end of an interview for [role] at [company], based on this posting [paste].
```

Then: Pick 2 to ask. One about the work, one about how success is measured.

6. PROTECT THE JOB YOU HAVE

26 Find which parts of your job AI can do also in the free library

```
Split every task in this job description into 3 columns: AI can do it today / AI makes it faster / Still needs a human. Put it in a table: [paste]
```

Then: Column 1 is your risk. Learn to do column 2 faster than anyone. Put column 3 at the top of your resume.

27 Messy notes to a status report also in the free library

```
Turn these notes into a status report with 3 sections: Done, At Risk, Decisions Needed. Under 150 words. Flag anything with no owner or date: [notes]
```

Then: Send it every Friday. People who report clearly get seen as the ones running things.

28 Handle a last-minute request also in the free library

```
Write a short, friendly reply to this request. Confirm what's due and when, offer two scope options (a quick version or a full version), and ask which matters most: [message]
```

Then: Let your boss pick the scope. You stop guessing and they feel heard.

29 Make your wins visible

```
From this list of what I did this month [paste], write a 5-bullet update for my manager that leads with results and numbers.
```

Then: Save every one of these. They become your resume bullets and your review notes.

30 Your 30-day backup plan

```
I still have my job but layoffs are rumored. Give me a 30-day plan, 20 minutes a day, to update my resume, LinkedIn, network and savings without anyone noticing.
```

Then: Start with your resume and savings. Those two take longest to fix in a hurry.

WORKED EXAMPLE: ONE RESUME BULLET

Before	What the AI asked	After (with your real numbers)
Responsible for managing vendor relationships and contracts.	"How many vendors? Did costs, delivery times or renewal rates change while you managed them?"	Managed 14 vendor contracts worth $2.1M a year; renegotiated 5 renewals and cut annual costs 12%.

The numbers here are an example. Yours must be real: the prompt is built to ask you for them instead of making them up.

YOUR FIRST 14 DAYS AFTER A LAYOFF

Day 1	File for unemployment if your state allows it now. Run prompt 4 (money runway).
Day 1	Send prompt 2's questions to HR in one email. Run prompt 10 (deadlines).
Day 2	Send your goodbye (prompt 3) and save personal contacts you're allowed to keep.
Day 2	Read your agreement with prompt 7. Don't sign yet.
Day 3	Ask for a reference (prompt 9). Decide on health coverage (prompt 8).
Day 4	Negotiate with prompt 6 if anything looks improvable.
Day 5	Rest. Seriously. Take one full day off.
Day 6	Rewrite your top 3 resume bullets (prompt 11 and the example).
Day 7	Cut your resume to one page (prompt 13). Add the layoff line (prompt 14).
Day 8	Update your LinkedIn headline and About (prompts 16 and 17).
Day 9	Message 3 former coworkers (prompt 18). Repeat every weekday.
Day 10	List target companies (prompt 20) and find one person at each.
Day 11	Apply to 3 roles that fit, matching each with prompt 12.
Day 12	Prepare 'tell me about yourself' and 'why did you leave' (prompts 21 and 22).
Day 13	Build 5 STAR stories (prompts 23 and 24).
Day 14	Review: what worked, who answered, what to do more of next week.

Unemployment rules, deadlines and benefits differ by state and country. Check your state's labor department site.

BEFORE YOU SIGN: SEVERANCE CHECKLIST

Have a clear written answer to each of these before you sign anything. Prompts 6, 7 and 10 help with most of them.

- ☐ Final paycheck date and what it includes (unused vacation, commissions)
- ☐ Severance amount, how it's paid (lump sum or over time) and when
- ☐ Health coverage end date and COBRA cost
- ☐ Bonus: earned, prorated, or lost?
- ☐ Equity: what vests, what's forfeited, and the deadline to exercise options
- ☐ Release of claims: what rights you're giving up by signing
- ☐ Deadline to sign, and any revocation period after signing
- ☐ Non-compete, non-solicit or confidentiality terms, and how long they last
- ☐ Whether you can get a reference or neutral reference, in writing
- ☐ Outplacement or career services offered
- ☐ Return of equipment: what, where, by when
- ☐ What happens to your 401(k) and any employer match

If the agreement has a release of claims, a non-compete, or anything you don't understand, an hour with an employment lawyer is worth it.

Want this done for your exact job?

The AI Career Firewall Audit: send your resume and LinkedIn, and get back a 1-page layoff-readiness plan plus 5 AI prompts written for your role, within 48 hours. $39.

Get your audit →

New prompts every week in the free prompt library.